

Photographs by YASIR IQBAL

THE ART OF WEAVING PASHMINA IS INTRICATE AND TIME-CONSUMING, REQUIRING SKILLED **ARTISANS WHO WORK ON THREAD AS THIN AS 10-16 MICRONS—THINNER THAN HUMAN HAIR**

Hussain joined a handloom workshop after quitting school in 1989. Initially, he would weave shawls on a handloom out of the delicate and soft yarn of the world's finest and most expensive wool, Shahtoosh. Later, after trade in Shahtoosh was banned, he used the Pashmina wool.

The art of weaving Shahtoosh or Pashmina is intricate and time-consuming, requiring skilled artisans who have to work on thread as thin as 10 microns to 16 microns—much thinner than a strand of human hair (70 microns). Procured from the underfur of the high-altitude Chiru antelope found in the Tibetan plateau, Shahtoosh was always exorbitantly priced, something only the plutocracy could afford.

But Chirus are endangered animals and Shahtoosh trade was banned globally in 1975 under the Convention on International Trade in Endangered Species (CITES), to which India is a signatory. The antelope is also listed in Schedule I of India's Wildlife (Protection) Act. An initially reluctant J&K government led by Farooq Abdullah extended the ban in 2000, hitting the livelihood of about 15,000 people. In 2017, a parliamentary panel led by Congress MP Renuka Chowdhury recommended lifting the ban, suggesting instead the "conservation and breeding of chiru goats", in order to preserve the livelihood of Shahtoosh weavers.